

ing after birds in Jharkhand's Ichakuti village in Singhbhum, bow and arrow in hand. Heading off to the event that will define him forever, India's best archer says, "Whatever's expected, whatever effort's expected to win, I will do it."

Allright, so they're all going to the Beijing Olympics, tricolours and hearts firmly affixed to sleeves. They are determined, which is encouraging, and realistic, which is useful. But something's not right. What's missing is the familiar soundtrack to every Indian Olympic departure. That last-minute crescendo of panic: where's-my-visa/coach/shoes/equipment? Our hockey team, customary architect of Olympic angst, is absent from the Games for the first time since a mouse called Mickey showed up on screen. In Beijing, India's individual athletes will be up on mainstage with nothing between them and the spotlight. It is a daunting prospect, so how come things

no gold medals for guessing where the herd usually heads. Yet, in the last few years, a few individuals have put the weight of their influence behind India's most promising athletes. These are not mere sponsors but investors in optimism, venture capitalists sinking capital into that most uncertain of ventures: the making of a sporting champion. Their resources and motivations are varied but their common mission is to give India's elite athletes every opportunity to crack the very top bracket, to make of our most worthy contenders, Olympic heroes.

The foremost of these programmes is the Mittal Champions Trust (MCT). Set up in November 2005 by steel baron Lakshmi Mittal, it commits \$10 million (Rs 43.5 crore) to a wide-ranging project aimed at a concerted medal push by India in the 2012 London Olympics.

AFP PHOTO/PAUL CROCK



Rifle shooting

GAGAN NARANG, 25

The man in form heading into Beijing, Hyderabad-based Narang is one of the two athletes being funded by the Olympic Gold Quest. The last to qualify for Athens 2004, Narang was the first shooter to get to Beijing.

"People know they need to watch out for me."

sound under control for this small bunch?

There is an explanation. Athletes like Nehwal, Narang & Co, admittedly only a handful from the Olympic contingent, are heading for Beijing with time and space to spare. The time to concentrate, the space to prepare. This group—and a dozen more like them—are the beneficiaries of the first sustained push for India's sporting elite by private enterprise. It may only be a small stirring, but in Olympic year, it is proving to be a significant one.

India Inc's outlook on sport is, by and large, governed by a herd mentality, with

The Olympic Gold Quest (OGQ) is an effort from two Indian sporting legends Prakash Padukone and Geet Sethi backed by business brains, which will raise funds for deserving candidates, all in the search for that elusive individual Olympic gold.

As far as single sport goes, tennis has its own targeted programme, Apollo Tyres' Mission 2018. Launched at the end of 2007, it aims at 'creating' a singles Grand Slam champion from India inside a decade. The programme, which earmarked Rs 100 crore over the next 10 years, has just made its first selection of